Tzav 5783

This week is פרשת צו, which is שבת הגדול, the great שבת before our wonderful יום טוב of פסח. שבת הגדול is called by this name for many reasons. One reason is that לדור דורות the דרשה on the הלכות of פסח was given on this שבת. Since it was a major דרשה, it became known as שבת הגדול. Another reason is that on this day, בני ישראל were commanded to take the שה, tie it to the bedpost, and prepare it as the קרבן פסח. This was a great נס.

What was the נס? The נס was that the מצריים didn't react. משה רבינו had protested to Hashem, saying, "בני ישראל can't do this! The שה is מצרים's עבודה זרה, and they will kill us!" Hashem responded, "חייך - I swear, they are not leaving מצרים until they do exactly that." Now, within the great panoply of מכות, ניסים, and the entire story of יציאת מצרים, tying a שֶׂעפֶסֶל to the bedpost seems like a rather minor detail, yet we call it שבת הגדול. What is the underlying message here?

We can gain some insight into what הקדוש ברוך הוא considers to be גדול, and how we should orient ourselves by looking at another instance where the word גדול is used. Where do we find this? At קריעת ים סוף, which took place at the end of פסח. What does the פסוק which we recite every day in davening, say? וַיַּרְא יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶת הַיָּד הַגְּדֹלָה אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה ה' בְּמִצְרַיִם - They witnessed the great hand of Hashem, in that which he did to מצרים. This is written immediately after קריעת ים סוף.

The Lutzker Rav, the אזנים לתורה, asks an important question. There were two aspects to קריעת ים סוף. The first was the incredible נס of the sea splitting, allowing בני ישראל to cross, a once-in-history event. The second was that, while בני ישראל were still crossing, the sea returned to its place, drowning the מצריים. The question is: which of these two events is referred to as the יד הגדולה?

The answer is that it refers not to the splitting of the sea, but to the drowning of the מצריים. בני ישראל witnessed the יד השם, not just in the supernatural event of the sea splitting, but in what seemed to be a natural occurrence - the water returning to its place. They were able to experience, realize, and internalize that הקדוש ברוך הוא runs the world, even in the mundane forces of nature, such as gravity.

This is what גדולה truly is. גדולה is recognizing השם אחד ושמו אחד and living with the awareness of שִׁוִּיתִי ה' לְנֶגְדִּי תָמִיד. We must realize that Hashem is constantly with us - no matter what we are doing, no matter how we act. גדולה is present in every moment, in every step we take, in every breath we breathe. We must appreciate this and keep it in mind as we navigate our daily routines and the challenges that עולם הזה presents. All of these difficulties and stresses are designed to help us learn more and more about Hashem's חסד and His הנהגה in the world - to recognize that Hashem is the מנהיג העולם. One crucial lesson we should take from פסח is that Hashem's involvement in the world is not a one-time event but an ongoing reality, even in simply tying the sheep to the bedpost.

An additional point to mention, since we are in פרשת צו and can't overlook it. The קרבן תודה is mentioned in פרשת צו. As we know, the תודה is a קרבן brought for many reasons. The גמרא lists four specific cases in which a person brings a קרבן תודה: someone who traveled across the ocean, someone who traveled through the מדבר, someone who was sick and recovered, and someone who was in the בית הסורים and was released.

All of these situations involve ישועות from Hashem, and they warrant bringing a קרבן תודה. It's important for us to keep this in mind as well. Every day, except for שבת, we say מזמור לתודה in our תפילה. Why don't we say it on שבת? Because the קרבן תודה could not be brought on שבת. Interestingly, it also could not be brought on פסח, since it was offered together with לחם חמץ.

Both שבת and פסח are paradigms of הכרת הטוב. שבת is the great gift of Hashem - an island of serenity in our pressured work week. As we approach פסח, we have to remember to constantly say, "Thank you, thank you, thank you," all day long, for all of the חסד that Hashem does for us. One of the most powerful

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examples of הכרת הטוב in the תורה is found in the story of יציאת מצרים. רש"י, in פרשת בשלח, explains that when the פסוק says וַחֲמֻשִׁים עָלוּ בְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל מֵאֶרֶץ מִצְרָיִם, it means that בני ישראל left מצרים armed. If they were armed, why was it necessary for הקדוש ברוך הוא to perform the extraordinary נס of קריעת ים סוף? Why didn't בני ישראל simply turn around and fight off the מצריים who were pursuing them?

The חתם סופר answers this question with a remarkable insight. The הכרת הטוב that בני ישראל owed to the מצריים prevented them from fighting against them. This is astounding. After all the years of suffering, oppression, and cruelty - after the מצריים had murdered their children and forced them into unbearable labor - still, the תורה teaches us that כלל ישראל remained bound by a sense of הכרת הטוב. Why? Because, despite everything, מצרים had originally welcomed them as guests and had provided them with a place to live.

This shows us the depth to which הכרת הטוב must extend. הקדוש ברוך הוא had to perform the נס of קריעת ים סוף specifically so that כלל ישראל would not have to engage in battle against מצרים. בעזרת השם, in the merit of expressing gratitude - both to Hashem and to others - may we continue to receive ברכה and הצלחה. May Hashem continue to shower us with His kindness, and may we soon merit to see the גאולה שלמה with the coming of משיח צדקנו, במהרה בימינו.

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